

Dullness and Lethargy: Our Two Very Good Friends

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Tips of the Day · 3 min read

I'm at Satipanya as I write this, on the second day of a two week retreat and, as is usual for me during the first few days of a retreat (at least!), dullness and lethargy is the prevalent state. I'm used to this. It doesn't seem to matter what I'm doing, when I switch from one mode of being to another, dullness and lethargy arises. That can be from work to retreat or retreat to work, it doesn't matter. Holidays are the same. Any major change in behaviour results in the same thing: dullness and lethargy! Bhante calls them "our two very good friends" as they're always trying to help you be more comfortable, to rest, to take it easy, and always for good and compelling reasons: you deserve it, you've worked so hard, and so on. It's interesting to watch. For me, dullness and lethargy typically starts in the mind. Often, what happens is that I notice a warm and comfortable aspect of experience which envelopes me, and before I know it I'm nodding off! As the dullness develops, it can migrate from mere sleepiness to a full-on (off?!) physical lethargy, like the energy supply has been disconnected! It lulls you in like that. Dreamlike thoughts/images grab at you, trying to pull you down into the depths of sleep. This is, of course, exactly how sleep starts normally. Typically, I'll close my eyes and reflect on something from the day, this quickly turns into a weird hypnagogic semi-dream and I'm gone. The feeling and character is just like dullness and lethargy, though. Stuff going on in the mind "takes over" and drags you down into sleep. So, the "problem" definitely appears to be the mind and, by that, I mean paying unwise attention to the contents of the mind. When mindfulness is present, and we're diligent with watching physical sensations in the body, it's much harder for dullness and lethargy to get a foothold. From a meditative point of view, I pretty much equate getting lost in thought with dullness and lethargy. I know that if the mind is thinking a lot, dullness and lethargy is sure to follow. While meditating, there's an apparent conflict with our "friends", though. We want to be alert, but they can make for an unpleasant and unsatisfactory experience. Dullness and lethargy is not the enemy, though. It's not a "problem". It's the mind's conditioned strategy for dealing with difficult situations, disinterest, disengagement, boredom and so on. As such, it's automatic, so I try not to fight it any more. Instead, I try to gently feed in the conditions for interest and alertness to arise. I try to stay awake, I'll keep my eyes open, stand up, walk, and so on. That is, all the usual instructions for dealing with dullness and lethargy, but I also look for something interesting, that is, I'll try to encourage my "perspective" to be that of a curious child. There's something amazing about the way the breath feels when it breathes itself. What makes it breathe in long sometimes and short others? Sometimes it's steady, sometimes it huffs. Oftentimes it feels like I'm not getting enough air, but the breath carries on like that anyway, and I don't keel over! What?! Also, the feeling of standing back and watching the body running on without "my" input is remarkable. It really shows that this body is not-Self! Also, when dullness and

lethargy has grabbed me, it's fascinating to be lolling about in its stupor one moment, and then wide awake and fully engaged the next! That happens of itself, too! So, far from being a "problem", dullness and lethargy is actually fertile ground for great investigation and insight. Impermanent, unsatisfactory, and not-Self, our two very good friends, dullness and lethargy, turn out to be a great vipassanā teacher!

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